Territory exercises a hegemonic influence in global political organization, due to the strength and priority of the notion of the nation-state. At the symbolic level, effective control of territory is a sine qua non condition for survival in international politics (Buzan 1991; Toft 2006). The structure of global politics requires communities to exercise effective control over territory as supreme authorities (demonstrate state-sovereignty, or something equivalent for de facto states), both as proof of their ability to rule themselves and as a means of visibly claiming a place in the world of sovereign communities. The strong presence of territory as the spatial manifestation of the presence and survival of political communities is inherent to this idea. Ethnicity and nationalistic identity are often employed as the main narratives for survival in such international relations, which invest their claim to territory with legitimizing moral value and make the cause imperative and non-negotiable (Laoutides and Kingsbury 2015). In this context ethnic and national conceptions of identity seem to be the only collective identities able to qualify for citizenship and participation in a territorially demarcated and organized global political society. Beyond affective and cultural attachment, therefore, territory is instrumentally important for the material aspect of Kachin community survival. It is a means to ensure self-government, economic survival, and the survival of cultural identity.

Recent scholarship has stressed that violent action against the state requires economic and political opportunity. Collier and Hoeffler (1998, 2002) link armed resistance with the availability of both financing (particularly abundant natural resources) and potential recruits (individuals with reduced prospects of material advancement through peaceful activity). There is a growing consensus that insurgent access to resource revenues prolongs armed conflicts and presents significant hurdles to peace, although in Kachin State the issue is potentially as much one of the perceived protection of natural resources from exploitation by the state or state-sanctioned international investors. Many Kachin actors and international advisors pointed out that the Kachin take issue with the 2008 Constitution, which declares that all natural resources belong to the central state, not states and regions, and fear that the Tatmadaw is waging war against them to gain control over vast resources wealth, hence loss of control and identity.

The scramble for the control of resources in the Kachin area thus appears to be a symptom rather than the cause of the conflict. Resources